MADHYA PRADESH

INDORE'S BATTLE AGAINST BEGGING

By Rahul Noronha



▲ **SOCIAL SWEEP** Indore district administration officials rescuing a beggar in the city to rehabilitate her, Jan. 12

Indore, seven-time winner of India's cleanest city honour, has in the past year been on another clean-up mission—eliminating beggary. Launched in February 2024, the anti-begging initiative has shown promising results, offering a model that could potentially be replicated nationwide. Spearheaded by the district administration and the women and child development (WCD) department, it is a three-phase programme that combines counselling, rescue and enforcement.

In the first phase, WCD officials counselled 3,500 beggars and their families—children in the case of elderly beggars and parents in the case of minors—advising them to give up begging. The second phase involved rescue and rehabilitation. Those who persisted despite counselling were taken to the Sewa Dham Ashram in the city. Here, they received medical care besides Aadhaar and Ayushman Bharat health insurance cards, as well as food coupons. Physically challenged beggars without family support were offered permanent residence at the ashram. By December 2024, 470 individuals had been rescued and rehabilitated.

For at least some beggars in Indore, begging seemed more a lucrative habit than a need. One beggar, for instance, had travelled from Kurnool in Andhra Pradesh by train in an AC three-tier coach, while another had Rs 2 lakh in a bank account. A third owned a house worth Rs 50 lakh in the city. "We found 22 beggars who had travelled to Indore by bus and regularly stayed in a hotel near a bus stand, paying Rs 450 a night," says Dinesh Mishra, project officer, WCD department, and nodal officer for the programme. Religious sites, he added, were a significant lure for beggars, among them groups of youth travelling from nearby Ratlam to collect alms in the name of Shani Dev. Some beggars reported daily earnings of Rs 1,000-1,500, far more than they'd earn in any labour-intensive work.

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This month, the programme entered its third phase, focusing on enforcement. District magistrate Asheesh